

Buried in a Genealogy

PRIMARY TEXT: Genesis 11:10–32

What does it look like to fully trust the Story?

What does it look like to put others, even those the world calls useless or outcasts, before yourself?

What does it look like to set aside your own security—your own legacy—for another? As we begin to study the life and legacy of Avram, we may start unveil a clearer picture of what this can look like.

What does it look like to put others, even those the world calls useless or outcasts, before yourself?

One image that answers these questions is that of Avram. The man who is initially buried in a list of difficult-to-pronounce names and sacrifices his legacy, his patriarchal lineage, to bring a barren, outcast woman into the fold—into his father’s household, his *beit av*. Avram’s decision to choose this one young woman over his own security can lead us to so many images of the God of Israel throughout Torah and Tanakh and Jesus in the Gospels. But that would be getting ahead of ourselves...

Throughout the Text so far, we have seen humankind at its best and worst. So many of those created in God’s image choose to try and maintain their own security at the expense of others, consequently impacting their relationship with God. Adam and Eve chose their desire. Cain chose to try and acquire by his own means. Noah chose to play god and curse a lineage of descendants. Nimrod chose to overthrow and build a tower to secure his own power.

He chooses someone other than himself, and in doing so finds a different kind of legacy altogether.

However, Abraham does the exact opposite of so many of his ancestors. He chooses someone other than himself, and in doing so finds a different kind of legacy altogether.

When Avram chooses to marry Sarai, God has finally found someone who understands what it means to trust the Story. Doing the right thing in spite of his own fears, fully understanding that his actions do not benefit him at all—in fact, they have done the opposite—and trusting that God is bigger than He can comprehend or the legacy he can acquire.

So what does it look like to trust the Story?

What does it look like to put the wellbeing of the outcast or orphan before your own? What does it look like to recognize your future may be altered by the choice to improve the future of another?

The answers are buried in this patriarchal genealogy, pointed out to us near the names of two women, and continues through the story of Avram. Not a perfect man, by any means, but the one who finally looks to God and says, “I choose you. I choose compassion and justice and goodness and hospitality and righteousness over what I can attain or what the world says is my rightful legacy.”

**I choose you—over
what I can attain or
what the world says
is my rightful legacy.**

Avram put himself aside, and in doing so he became one of God’s greatest partners in this Story. This brief genealogy doesn’t just introduce us to Abraham, it shows us not just *what* it looks like to trust the Story, but how we can partner with God in the Story here and now too.

PRAYER

God

*Thank you for never giving up on humankind—on me
For showing me what it looks like
to trust the Story.*

Thank you for the ability to choose.

Help me to choose like you—like Abraham.

To choose love over legacy.

Goodness over comfort.

Trust over security.

Faith over doubt.

As the sun rises and as the sun sets

I choose righteousness, justice, compassion, and hospitality.

I choose You.

Amen

THE FOUR PILLARS

EPISODE 8

BEMA Discipleship is built on four pillars; a **Four-Pillared Perspective** to help us remember **to elevate the words of God** (not ours) and help us identify the principles that we see recurring in the Story of God's people.

Here are some applications for this episode echoing the ideas of the four pillars:



TEXT

How could you meditate over this genealogy? What Text could you continue to meditate on, memorize, or dig deeper into?



COMMUNITY

In what ways does your community instill or challenge your ideas on security, what is rightfully yours, or trusting the Story? What ideas are you left with about community when considering Avram choosing Sarai?



DISCIPLESHIP

Who in your life would benefit from being brought into this part of trusting the Story? Who needs to hear that God's ways may not look the way the world's do? How do you model the image of Avram choosing to trust the Story, or who models this for you?



WRESTLING

What questions do you have after this lesson? How could you wrestle with the names and characters of Iscah and Sarai? Or the concept of Sarai's barrenness or Avram's patriarchal significance? Questions were/are the point!



Are you a music listener?

Listen along to our BEMA Music Playlists on Spotify.

Song suggestions? Send them to bemabesorah@gmail.com.



BEMA SESSION 1



MEDITATION & PRAYER

REFLECTION, APPLICATION & IMPACT

There are three emphases we are always thinking about in terms of application at BEMA. These may be stated explicitly at times, but often we will want you to do the work of finding ways to connect the dots to the things we are learning. Much of this is what makes the work of BEMA distinct as a ministry of Impact Campus Ministries.

CREATING A SPACE *SPIRITUAL FORMATION*

*We believe that **if we do our part of creating space for God, He will fill it!** We want BEMA to foster practices that enable the Holy Spirit to do a work in and through us all. How can you begin, or how are you now, creating this space after thinking through the Preface of the Text? Where in life do you have, or could you create, space to hear or feel God challenging you to trust the Story? To rely on Him and hear His voice and over the voices of this world?*

CONSIDERING CAMPUS *YOUNG PEOPLE FOCUS*

*We believe young adults are shaping the future of this world, and they need to see and hear the stories of people **TODAY** trusting the Story too! In what ways could you come alongside young adults to model trusting the Story, to encourage them to do the same, and to show them that the Kingdom looks so different—like Avram—because our God is so very good.*

SACRED STATION *THEOLOGY OF WORK*

*This may be about what we do at work—but it's also about those we interact with every day. Do we look for the Sarai or the Iscah? Do we look for ways to bring others into the fold of our workplace or homes or church so their lives can be good, along with our own, or do we compartmentalize our “work” so much that it is only about moving ourselves forward and securing our own future? The way we manage employees and interact with customers or coworkers or families says a lot about the God we believe in, and our actions of compassion, justice, and hospitality speak so much louder than our words or workplace policies. **The work we do every day is sacred. It matters to the Kingdom!***